

Soft Power Through (Humanitarian) Aid: Evidence from an RCT in Pakistan*

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Abstract

Foreign aid budgets are experiencing severe cuts as voters question whether aid serves donor interests beyond moral obligations. This paper examines whether an important component of foreign aid, humanitarian aid – emergency assistance in crisis settings – can function as soft power, shaping recipients' values, attitudes, and political behaviours, key donor goals. I conduct a randomised controlled trial with 2,450 vulnerable women in Pakistan, cross-randomising humanitarian aid receipt (four monthly payments of 25 USD) with information identifying the aid's foreign source. The interventions successfully address immediate needs and correct beliefs about aid origins. I find three key results for soft power. First, while aid and information each improve perceptions of foreign organizations when provided separately, their combination generates the strongest impact (10% increase). Second, the combination generates modest shifts in cultural tolerance, although broader value changes remain limited. Third, and most surprisingly, foreign aid information increases support for Pakistan's government by 0.1σ , due to recipients interpreting international presence as signalling improving domestic institutional prospects. These results demonstrate humanitarian aid's potential as a soft power tool, particularly when recipients understand its source.

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1 Introduction

Foreign aid faces an existential crisis. The UK has slashed its aid budget to 0.3% of GNI by 2027, the lowest share since 1999, while the United States has dismantled US-AID and European donors have announced similar freezes. These cuts come precisely as humanitarian needs reach unprecedented levels – the UN’s 2024 humanitarian appeal hit record levels, with 339 million people requiring assistance ([IRC, 2025](#)). This retreat reflects a fundamental challenge: voters and politicians increasingly question whether aid serves any strategic purpose beyond moral obligation. Polls show that 61% of Americans believe their government spends "too much" on foreign aid, while 66% of UK citizens supported recent cuts ([Kaiser Foundation, 2013](#); [YouGov, 2020](#)). In an era of transactional foreign policy, aid must justify itself not only through moral imperatives but also through tangible benefits to donor nations. The question of whether aid can advance national interests – long debated since [Morgenthau \(1962\)](#) framed it as an instrument of power – has become urgent in practice.

This tension is particularly acute for humanitarian aid, which comprises a substantial and growing share of total foreign aid flows: Its moral objective is clear, yet it faces the deepest scepticism about its strategic value for donors. These transfers – reaching hundreds of millions of people and totalling \$46.9 billion in 2024 – provide immediate, life-saving assistance to populations facing crises from conflict, disasters, and displacement. Donors have repeatedly attempted to leverage these massive flows for political purposes, yet rigorous evidence on whether such attempts succeed is lacking. Humanitarian aid flows overwhelmingly to fragile states where governments cannot meet citizens’ basic needs and where small shifts in people’s attitudes, values and politics can have important consequences for long-term social and political equilibria, making this question especially pressing.

In this paper, I study whether humanitarian aid can serve as an instrument of soft power. Soft power – the ability to shape preferences through appeal and attraction rather than coercion ([Nye, 1990](#)) – requires influencing recipients’ beliefs, attitudes and opinions. Soft power matters because it allows countries to achieve foreign policy goals without military force or economic sanctions. For humanitarian aid to serve as soft power, it must do more than save lives: It must shape how recipients think about foreign actors, influence their fundamental values and worldviews, and potentially affect their political behaviours.

I provide experimental evidence through a randomised controlled trial with 2,450 extremely vulnerable women in Pakistan, cross-randomising two interventions in a 2×2 design. First, randomly selected participants receive four monthly humanitarian aid payments of ~25 USD each – assistance designed to meet immediate basic needs. Second, I randomly provide information identifying the aid’s source as an international donor, explicitly stating that the Pakistani government played no role. This research design enables me to pinpoint what exactly matters for soft power: The aid

itself, the fact that it comes from a foreign donor, or the combination of both. This approach assesses whether humanitarian assistance can simultaneously achieve both strategic and humanitarian goals. I measure outcomes across three dimensions that are central to soft power and donors' goals: Perceptions of foreign actors, adoption of values donors promote, and political attitudes and behaviours. After verifying both interventions achieved their intended objectives, I examine how they affect these soft power outcomes.

Before examining soft power outcomes, I verify that both interventions achieved their intended objectives. Recipients spent aid primarily on food (93%) and medicine (76%), with corresponding improvements in humanitarian outcomes such as nutritional diversity, food security (0.17σ increase), access to medicine, and mental wellbeing (0.6σ improvement). The information leads to participants meaningfully updating their beliefs about the source of the funds: While initially only 36% of participants (correctly) believe the aid comes from an international donor, receiving the information during the surveys increases this by 44 percentage points, or 120% compared to the control mean. There is also an increase in their certainty of these beliefs of around 10%. These effects are concentrated among participants who initially (wrongly) believed that the aid did not come from an international donor, and persist over time across survey rounds. Overall, these results show that the interventions succeeded in 1) addressing humanitarian needs, and 2) correcting participants' beliefs about the source of the funds.

At a fundamental level, donors seek to improve their standing in the countries in which they operate. This is important because more positive views towards donors decrease support for anti-donor activities, provide diplomatic leverage, and lend legitimacy in case of future interventions or projects in the recipient country. I find that both the aid and the information, when considered in isolation, improve participants' views on the work of international organisations helping Pakistan in general, and women like them in particular. The effect of the aid itself is entirely driven by participants who correctly believed the aid came from an international donor to begin with. Moreover, the combination of the aid and the information has the strongest effect: It improves views on the work of international organisations by around 10% of the control mean, and significantly more than either the aid or the information in isolation. These results demonstrate the potential of humanitarian aid in enhancing recipients' perceptions of foreigners. These results show that humanitarian aid can effectively improve how recipients view foreign actors, particularly when they understand its source—a key soft power objective

Donors have long sought to foster particular values through aid. Western donors specifically have promoted liberal democratic values expected to advance market development, human rights, and peace, while generating ideological alignment. Examining outcomes that capture key elements of these values – including universalism and positive-sum thinking (Enke, Rodriguez-Padilla, and Zimmermann, 2022; Chinoy

[et al., 2025](#)) – I find limited but targeted effects. The combination of aid and information makes participants 5-7% more respectful toward individuals from different cultures, belief systems and social groups, though other values remain unchanged. These modest effects likely reflect both the intervention’s brief duration and the inherent difficulty of shifting fundamental values through light-touch interventions. Yet, they demonstrate that even short-term humanitarian interventions can influence core attitudes.

Lastly, one of the key soft power goals behind foreign aid has been to influence political behaviours in recipient countries, from strengthening friendly governments in challenging places, to undermining those considered hostile to the donor’s strategic interests. Using self-reported measures of views towards the government, I find that the combination of the aid and the information improves participants’ views of the national government by $\sim 0.1\sigma$. These results are corroborated by exploiting only within-subject variation and using incentivised, lab-in-the-field games ([Acemoglu et al., 2020](#); [Blair, Marty, and Roessler, 2022](#)), which allays concerns about the self-reported nature of these measures. This finding appears counterintuitive: Why would telling participants that the aid came from a foreign donor *increase* support for the national government? I demonstrate it is neither credit misattribution (the information explicitly states the government played no role) nor general life improvement (aid alone shows no effect). Instead, the mechanism appears to be more subtle: This combination conveys a positive signal about Pakistan’s institutional trajectory, which in turn improves participants’ views of the government. Indeed, the combination of the aid and the information makes participants more positive about the future of Pakistan’s political system, especially for women like themselves. This suggests that humanitarian aid can paradoxically strengthen support for domestic governments when recipients interpret the foreign presence as a positive signal about their country’s future prospects, rather than as evidence of state failure.

I find no effects on costlier political behaviours: Neither political participation inside or outside the household, nor a costly political task (signing a petition asking for more women’s rights) responds to any treatment combination. These null results were anticipated in my pre-analysis plan, likely reflecting the binding constraints on women’s political expression in this context, combined with the intervention’s limited duration. The precision of these estimates rules out even modest effects, confirming that while humanitarian aid can shift attitudes and perceptions, translating these into costly political actions requires either longer interventions or fewer structural barriers.

Overall, the results suggest that humanitarian aid has the potential to serve as a tool for soft power, in particular when combined with information about the source of the funds. The intervention successfully improves perceptions of foreign actors, generates modest shifts in cultural attitudes, and – most surprisingly – strengthens support for the domestic government through a signalling mechanism. These results prove robust to pre-specified experimenter demand tests and multiple hypothesis corrections,

with high lab game comprehension and a 96% response rate across two rounds of in-person surveys.

This paper makes three contributions. First, it provides experimental evidence on whether humanitarian aid can function as soft power by shaping recipients' values, attitudes, and political behaviours at the individual level. The political consequences of aid have generated extensive debate since [Morgenthau \(1962\)](#) framed assistance as an instrument of power. Yet existing evidence relies on aggregate country-level analyses ([Faye and Niehaus, 2012](#); [Wright, 2009](#); [Ahmed, 2012](#)), politicians' credit-claiming behaviour ([Guiteras and Mobarak, 2015](#); [Cruz and Schneider, 2017](#)), or hypothetical survey vignettes ([Blair and Roessler, 2021](#)). Closest to this paper, [Lyall, Zhou, and Imai \(2020\)](#) study the effect of a vocational and cash transfer program in Afghanistan, focusing on security outcomes in an active conflict zone rather than soft power objectives. My RCT with 2,450 humanitarian aid recipients provides causal evidence on whether this assistance can advance donor interests through soft power channels. By measuring effects on values, attitudes toward foreign actors, and political behaviours, and by cross-randomising information about the aid's foreign source, I demonstrate that humanitarian aid can function as soft power – finding that effects depend critically on recipients knowing the aid's foreign origin, with the combination generating improvements in foreign perceptions, modest value shifts, and surprisingly, enhanced government support through signaling mechanisms.

Second, I advance our understanding of how foreign intervention affects state-citizen relationships in fragile states. Recent literature demonstrates that improved state capacity or service delivery strengthens political engagement ([Acemoglu et al., 2020](#); [Montenbruck, 2023](#); [Weigel, 2020](#); [Weigel and Kabue Ngindu, 2023](#)). This paper examines the inverse: How citizens respond when foreign actors, not their government, provide essential services. The theoretical effect is ambiguous – foreign provision might undermine state legitimacy by highlighting government failure, or might enhance it by alleviating material hardship. My design, which randomises both aid receipt and information about its foreign source, allows me to disentangle these competing effects, finding that humanitarian aid increases government support when recipients interpret international presence as validation of institutional viability. This finding is especially important in fragile states where humanitarian flows concentrate, state capacity is minimal, and small shifts in values or political attitudes can reshape long-term social and political equilibria.

Third, I contribute to the literature on political effects of cash transfers by examining humanitarian assistance – a distinct and understudied transfer type that differs fundamentally from existing research. While studies of government-provided CCTs find mixed effects on political participation ([Labonne, 2013](#); [De La O, 2013](#); [Zucco Jr, 2013](#)) and individually-targeted transfers show minimal political impact ([Blattman,](#)

[Emeriau, and Fiala, 2018](#); [Broockman et al., 2024](#)),¹ humanitarian transfers merit distinct theoretical and empirical treatment due to their unique features. Unlike poverty alleviation programs, humanitarian aid provides emergency relief to crisis-affected populations facing acute deprivation. Crucially, it's delivered by foreign organisations in fragile states where sovereignty is contested and foreign presence politically charged. The combination of extreme vulnerability, foreign provision, and crisis contexts creates distinct political dynamics compared to domestic social protection. My results – showing that foreign identity matters critically for political effects – confirm that humanitarian transfers cannot be understood through the lens of standard cash transfer programs. This distinction matters as humanitarian aid totals \$46 billion annually and concentrates in politically unstable regions where understanding its political consequences is essential.

The rest of the paper is organised as follows. Section 2 describes the context in which the intervention took place and the sample. Section 3 describes the experimental design. Section 4 presents the results of the aid and information provision interventions. Section 5 presents the main results on the soft power outcomes. Section 6 discusses robustness checks. Section 7 concludes.

¹Yet more papers studying this question are [Manacorda, Miguel, and Vigorito \(2011\)](#), [Gromadzki, Sałach, and Brzeziński \(2024\)](#), [Hirvonen, Schafer, and Tukiainen \(2024\)](#) and [Zimmermann \(2021\)](#).

2 Context & Sample

2.1 Location

Pakistan is an interesting setting to study this question. First, it has the fourth-largest population in need of humanitarian assistance ([Development Initiatives, 2023](#)). Given concurrent economic and climate crises, this is unlikely to change in the near future, making the questions studied in this project highly relevant for the local context. Second, Pakistan is undergoing an interesting political moment. The Prime Minister Imran Khan was removed from office in 2022, with the elections delayed until 2024 and widely criticised ([The Guardian, 2024](#); [BBC, 2024](#)), which has led to nationwide protests in recent times. The Economist’s Intelligence Unit categorised Pakistan in 2024 as authoritarian for the first time since 2006, and the OECD classifies it as a fragile country, with high fragility in the political dimension. Thus, small shifts in values, attitudes and political behaviours can have important consequences on Pakistan’s institutions.

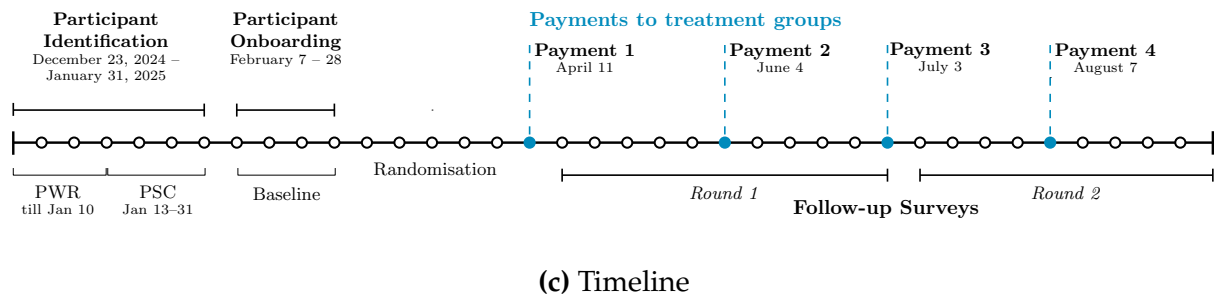
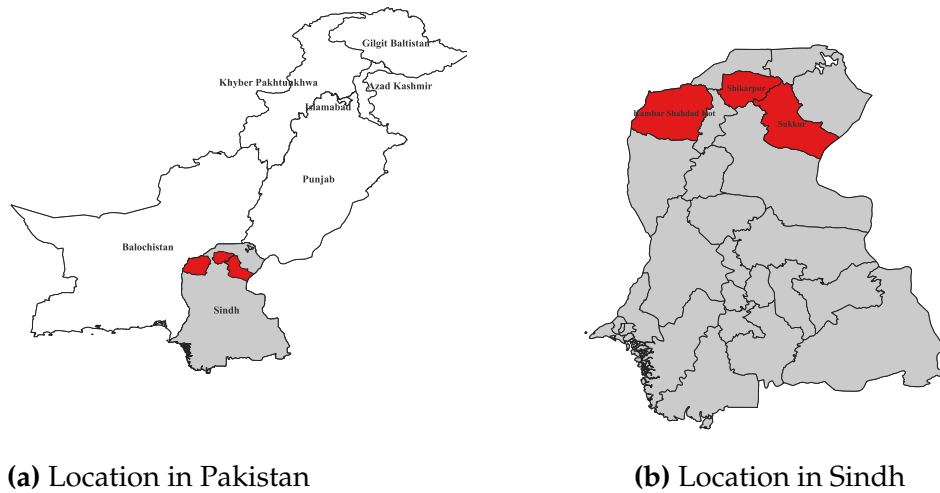
The project took place in the main urban areas of three districts in Sindh, Pakistan: Kamber, Shikarpur and Sukkur (Figure 1). These districts were selected for two main reasons. First, our local partners operate only in Sindh. Second, these districts, while very poor, vary in their local conditions, providing interesting variation to exploit. In each district, we worked in 12 different communities.

2.2 Participant Identification & Characteristics

Participants were selected through a rigorous two-step approach to identify the most vulnerable households in each community, which is explained in detail in [C](#) and briefly here (Figure 1 shows a timeline of the project). This was meant to have a sample with high levels of poverty and deprivation, similar to populations that receive humanitarian aid in other contexts. First, all households in the community were invited to a meeting in which the goal was to classify the community’s households into four different socioeconomic groups (“Participatory Wealth Ranking”, or PWR). To acknowledge local differences in what constitutes poverty/deprivation, participating households first identified a set of characteristics for each of the four socioeconomic groups and then classified each household into one of these groups. While moderators from our local partners were present to guide the activity, the ranking was based purely on the discussion by participants, who were told the activity was to better understand the socioeconomic situation of the community, not to select participants for a humanitarian project, to avoid strategic answering.

The 150 households in the lowest socioeconomic group in each community were selected for the second step, which consisted of collecting a short questionnaire based on socioeconomic questions widely used in Pakistan for similar programs, plus some

Figure 1: Locations & Timeline



Notes: The maps show the location of the three districts in which the intervention took place. Each node in the timeline denotes a week. Aid payments were made in weeks 16, 22, 27, and 32. The blue nodes highlight those payment weeks. PWR and PSC refer to the Participatory Wealth Ranking and Poverty Score Card exercises, respectively.

screening criteria (“Poverty Score Card”, or PSC).² Enumerators from our local partners visited each of the selected households to complete the questionnaire. The enumerators did not know the exact screening criteria nor the scoring rule based on the questionnaire to avoid manipulation. The responses were converted into poverty scores

²If there were more than 150 households in the lowest group, then a random sample of 150 was selected. If there weren't 150 households in the lowest group, then all households in the lowest group were selected, plus a random sample of households from the second lowest group needed to complete 150 households in a given community. In practice, almost all communities had enough households in the lowest group. In terms of screening, households were excluded if: They didn't have a valid national ID (CNIC) since they wouldn't be able to receive the aid payments; Were older than 65 years old or had a serious disability, since the piloting showed that these participants would struggle a lot to claim their funds and complete the surveys; or if they didn't have access to a mobile phone, which was needed to receive the payments (they didn't need to personally own a phone, but they did need to have access to a phone, for example from someone in the household). Fewer than 10% of participants were excluded for any of these reasons, see Table A5.

using a scoring rule, and the 70 poorest women (each representing a household) were selected for the study.

Among these 70 women in each community, 10 were set aside for the pure control group and 60 were invited to onboarding sessions. In these onboarding sessions, participants were informed for the first time that this was a humanitarian project and that two-thirds of participants would receive four aid payments worth 7,000 PKR (approximately 25 USD). Participants then provided their consent if they wanted to participate, and a short baseline survey was collected. Lastly, participants opened mobile wallets with the assistance of our mobile money partners, who also guided the women on how to use the wallets and provided them with a graphical brochure to aid their understanding. Our final sample consists of the 2,105 participants who attended the onboarding sessions and agreed to participate in the study (out of 2,160 invited) and the 360 in the pure control group, for a total of 2,465 participants.

Table 1 shows the baseline characteristics of the final sample. Participants are on average 40 years old, 84% have no education at all and 85% are married, with an average household size of 7.8 individuals. Around half state that they are the heads of their household. Participants are very poor, deprived and suffer from food insecurity: 97% are credit constrained (unable to raise a small amount of money in a short period of time), 22% and 50% are categorised as destitute and chronic poor, respectively, based on the poverty score, 53% and 33% have stressed or critical levels of food security (based on the Integrated Food Security Phase Classification, or IPC), respectively, and 47% and 46% are classified as being deprived and severely deprived based on the World Food Programme’s Multidimensional deprivation index (MDDI). Lastly, around three-quarters have experienced a shock in the previous 12 months (either man-made or natural), with low levels of mental well-being at baseline (less than one-fifth state that they are happy, and the average life satisfaction is 4.4 from 0 to 10). Overall, these characteristics suggest that the selection process successfully identified extremely poor and vulnerable participants.

3 Experimental Design

There are two main parts to this intervention. First, the intervention that randomly provides humanitarian aid to participants. Second, the intervention that randomly provides information on the source of the funds to participants. The goal of these two cross-randomised information was to be able to disentangle whether what matters is the aid itself, the fact that it comes from an international donor, or the combination of both. The experimental design is summarised in Figure 2.

Intervention 1: Aid Provision The main goal of the study was to understand the effects of humanitarian aid on a variety of outcomes, including soft power outcomes. To do so, participants were randomised into one of three arms, stratifying by their

Table 1: Baseline Characteristics

	Mean (1)	SE (2)	Percentiles					Obs. (8)
			10 th (3)	25 th (4)	50 th (5)	75 th (6)	90 th (7)	
Age	40.24	10.91	26	32	39	47	55	2465
Has no education	0.84	0.37						2465
Married	0.85	0.36						2350
Is head of household	0.52	0.5						2459
Involved in HH's fin. decision-making	0.21	0.41						2350
Number household members	7.77	3.01	5	6	7	9	11	2351
Lowest socioecon. group (PWR)	0.76	0.43						2465
Income (last 30 days)	17212.73	9722.43	6000	10000	15000	22000	30000	2351
Receives BISP	0.46	0.5						2465
Credit constrained	0.97	0.18						2346
PSC: Destitute	0.22	0.42						2465
PSC: Chronic poor	0.5	0.5						2465
Stressed food security	0.53	0.5						2098
Critical food security	0.33	0.47						2098
MDDI: Deprived	0.47	0.5						2095
MDDI: Severely deprived	0.46	0.5						2095
Experienced shock (last 12 months)	0.74	0.44						2105
Happy (=1)	0.19	0.39						2347
Life satisfaction (0–10)	4.41	2.32	1	3	5	5	7	2351

Notes: Some variables were not collected for the pure control group, hence the reduced number of observations. For the pure control group, we use the values of the outcome variables (income, happy, and life satisfaction) at the time of their first survey.

community, their baseline needs and whether they receive assistance from Pakistan's flagship social protection program (BISP):

1. *Control group (1065 participants):* None of these participants received any aid payments and serve as a control group. Among them, 705 participated in the onboarding sessions and are thus aware of the humanitarian campaign (onboarding control group), while the remaining 360 did not participate in the onboarding sessions and thus are unaware of the humanitarian program (pure control group).

The two different control groups are used to study experimenter demand effects and strategic answering among participants, as explained in Section 6.1.

2. *Aid in Cash treatment group (699 participants):* Participants in this treatment group received their aid through their national ID cards (CNIC), which they then needed to cash out. This is a “cash-light” way of delivering aid that mimics the most common way of delivering humanitarian aid nowadays.
3. *Digital Aid treatment group (701 participants):* Participants in this treatment group received their aid through mobile wallets opened with and for them. This digital approach to delivering humanitarian aid is new and has many potential advantages over traditional aid delivery mechanisms. This approach has been shown to work in other similar contexts (see, e.g., [Callen et al., 2025](#)).

Aid

Donor Information	No Aid	Receives Aid	
		Aid in Cash	Digital Aid
No Information			
Info on Donor Identity Only ----- + Values			

Figure 2: Experimental Design

Participants in the treatment groups receive four monthly aid payments, each worth 7,000 PKR (around 25 USD), which is what our partners believe is necessary to cover the basic needs of the average family for a month. In a companion paper, [Fajardo-Steinhäuser and Findley \(2025\)](#), we study the relative effectiveness of the two different aid delivery mechanisms. However, for this study, I combine both treated arms into a single treated group, since the aid delivery channel is unlikely to play an important role in shaping the soft power outcomes of interest in this study.

Intervention 2: Information Provision Participants are not provided any information about the source of the funds at any stage. During the identification process, participants were told that these exercises were being conducted to understand the socio-economic situation of these communities. During the onboarding sessions, participants heard about the humanitarian program for the first time but did not receive any information about the source of the funds or the involvement of a foreign donor.

As shown in Figure 1, participants were surveyed twice: Once after receiving the first or the second payment, and again after receiving the third or the fourth payment. The payments were not linked to the surveys. During each survey, participants were asked questions on humanitarian outcomes, agency, and soft power outcomes, and two lab-in-the-field games were played.³ Each lab game was played twice, and the information was randomly provided immediately after participants had completed the first round of the games. The information provision was stratified by participants' treatment assignment in the aid intervention and whether they receive BISP. All soft power questions were asked after the information was provided. Thus, for the lab games, I can exploit within-individual variation from the rounds before and after the information is provided, while for the other outcomes, I can only exploit across-individual variation.

³Participants received a payment of 500 PKR for completing the survey, and up to 1,000 PKR based on their responses in the lab games. The average participant received a payment of ~1,350 per survey (around 5 USD).

Two messages were provided to participants. Half of the participants (“Donor Identity Only”) were told the following:

“As part of the project, 2 out of 3 participants that attended the event in February received payments of 7000 PKR to help them improve their economic situation. The money for this project and the payments came from an international donor outside of Pakistan. This international donor is an organization that funds projects related to economic development all over the world, including this. This international organization has funded other projects in Pakistan in the past. Without the funding of this international organization, it would not have been possible to conduct this project or to support the women in this project. The Pakistani government played no role in this project.”

The goal of the message was twofold: First, to highlight that the money came from an international donor. Second, to explicitly state that the Pakistani government played no role in the project. The other half of participants received exactly the same information plus the following message (“Donor Identity plus Values”):

“This type of foreign assistance is much needed in Pakistan: 1 out of 5 people in Pakistan is undernourished, and one in three people living in districts like yours are facing serious levels of food insecurity. The work of international organisations like the one funding this project has prevented many deaths, sent many children to schools, and provided health services to people who would have otherwise not received these.”

The goal of this additional message was to highlight the values of the donor: Helping those most in need, despite the donor not being from Pakistan. In practice, the results are very similar across the two messages, so I only present the results combining those two groups together.

4 Impact of Interventions

In a first step, I confirm that the two interventions had their intended effect: The aid was spent on basic needs and led to improvements in humanitarian outcomes, and the information successfully corrected participants’ beliefs about the source of the funding.

4.1 Intervention 1: Impact of Humanitarian Aid

*“Before this, we didn’t have anything to eat.
At least now we can afford to have food,”*
34-year-old in Kamber

*“I bought groceries and medicines.
My child had been sick for a long time, so I got them treated,”*
23-year-old in Sukkur

*“We buy groceries, clothes for ourselves and our children,
we buy medicine for our kids that we were unable to buy before,”*

The primary objective of a humanitarian program is to deliver immediate, short-term, and direct relief to the most vulnerable populations, helping them cover their basic needs. Thus, I look at whether participants spent their funds covering these basic needs and the aid led to improvements in humanitarian outcomes. For a deeper discussion of the humanitarian impacts of the aid, and the relative effectiveness of different aid delivery modalities, see [Fajardo-Steinhäuser and Findley \(2025\)](#), a companion paper.

Figure 3 shows how participants spent their funds. The two most common categories were food (93% of participants) and medicine (76%), supporting the claim that participants had very high levels of needs and vulnerability. This matches qualitative quotes from participants describing how the aid payments affected their lives (see above). Other common categories were transport (63%), debt repayment (39%), clothes (38%) and school items for their kids (34%). Very few participants used their payments to save (11%) or start a business (8%), which suggests that the main use was relaxing immediate constraints rather than escaping long-term poverty (which is beyond what humanitarian aid aims to accomplish).

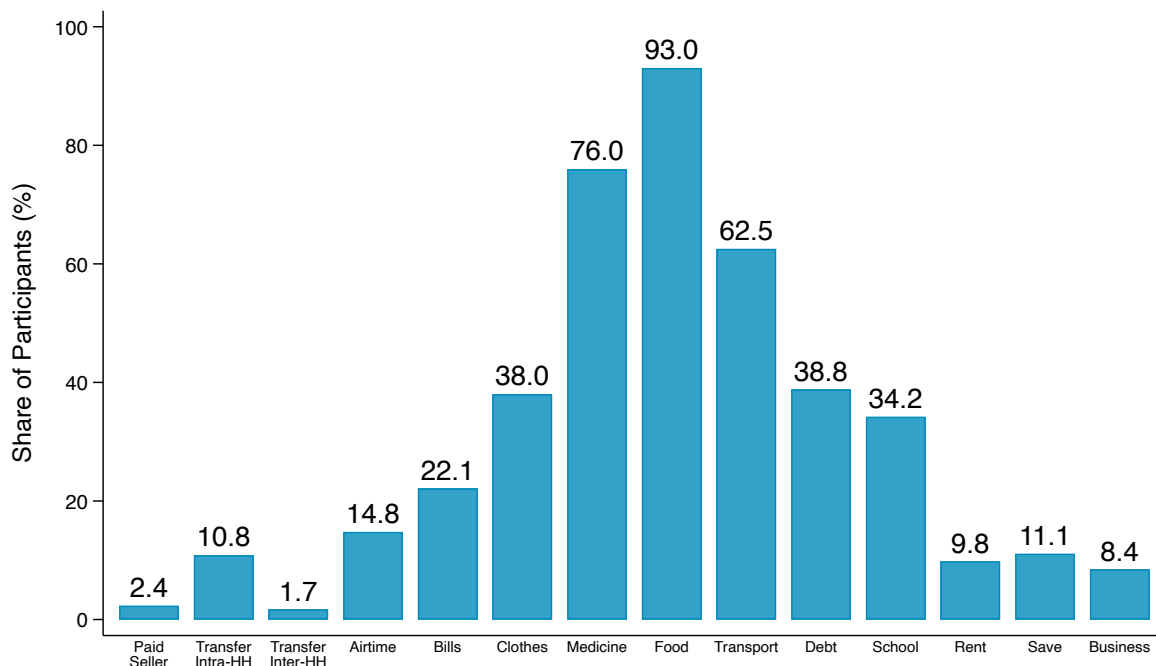


Figure 3: Aid Usage

Notes: The figure shows the proportion of participants who reported spending their aid money on different uses. Participants could indicate more than one use.

These patterns match the impacts on humanitarian outcomes observed. Table 2 shows the impact of the humanitarian aid on four main humanitarian outcomes. The first column shows that participants' nutritional diversity, as measured by their

Food Consumption Score (FCS), significantly increases. This is driven by an increase in the consumption of meats and fruits, two items that were seldomly consumed by the households. The second column shows a significant decrease in food insecurity of 0.17σ , a large effect. This reduction is driven by participants skipping fewer meals and going fewer days without eating, with the impacts concentrated among children aged 0 to 4. The third column shows that the aid enabled participants to buy more medicine (conditional on having had a medical emergency in the last 30 days), with an effect of almost 50% the mean in the control group. Lastly, column 4 shows large improvements in a mental well-being index of 0.61σ (while this is very large, it is not unprecedented in humanitarian settings, see, e.g., [Callen et al., 2025](#)). Participants report being happier, more satisfied with their lives, and that their economic situation has improved.

Table 2: Effect on Humanitarian Outcomes

	Nutritional Diversity (1)	Food Insecurity Index (2)	Afford to Buy Medicine (3)	Mental Wellbeing Index (4)
Received Aid	1.684*** (0.332)	-0.171*** (0.026)	0.129*** (0.046)	0.616*** (0.029)
Constant	34.338*** (0.258)	-0.001 (0.022)	0.289*** (0.011)	0.001 (0.022)
Observations	4,732	4,734	4,109	4,733
R^2	0.109	0.064	0.020	0.175

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. Controlling for strata fixed effects and survey round fixed effects. Paid for medicine is conditional on having a medical emergency that required buying medicine.

Overall, these results suggest that the aid was used for its intended purposes (alleviating short-term needs) and significantly improved humanitarian outcomes among participants.

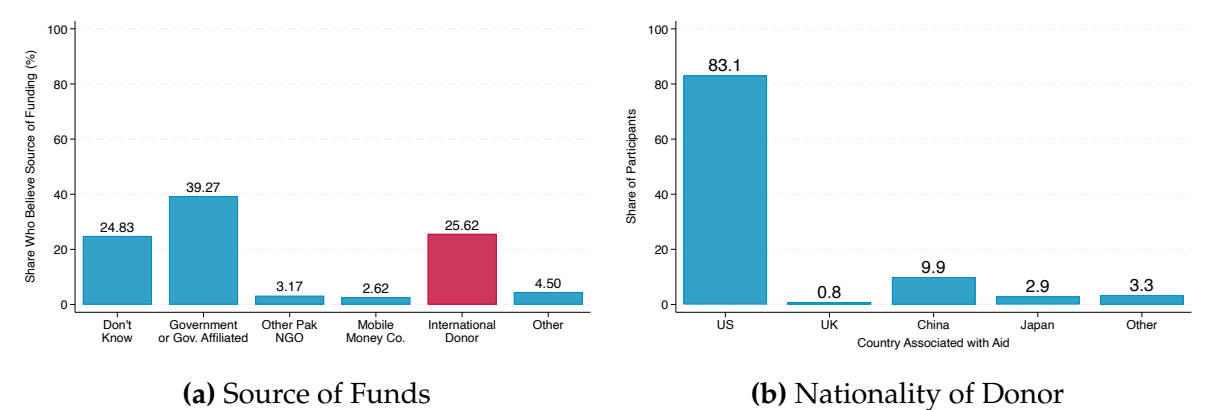
4.2 Intervention 2: Impact of Information Provision

At the beginning of each survey, participants were asked who they believed paid for the program. Enumerators were told not to read the options, but rather select the option closest to the participant's response. These beliefs were elicited at the end of the survey again to assess the effectiveness of the information intervention. Participants were also asked about their beliefs on the nationality of the donor in the second follow-up survey.⁴ Figure 4 shows the distributions of both beliefs. Panel A shows that most participants believe the aid comes from either the government or a government-affiliated organisation, with only a quarter of participants correctly identifying that the

⁴For those who correctly identified the donor to be foreign, they were asked for the identity of the donor. For the others, they were asked if the donor were foreign, what they believe is the most likely nationality of such a donor.

aid came from an international donor. Thus, there is a lot of room for these beliefs to be corrected. Panel B shows that most people associate any kind of foreign-funded humanitarian aid as coming from the US, with the second-most common nationality being China (less than 10%). Thus, even if participants are not explicitly told that the foreign aid came from an American donor (which was avoided to prevent any sensibilities associated with the US), most assume that is the case.

Figure 4: Respondents’ Beliefs About Source of Aid and Nationality of Foreign Donor



Notes: Panel A shows the distribution of the beliefs participants had at the beginning of the first follow-up survey (before any information was provided) about the source of the aid. Panel B shows the beliefs of participants at the end of the second survey on the nationality of the donor, conditional on the donor being foreign.

These results are important for several reasons. First, participants of development projects in general struggle to identify the funders of projects, despite the significant resources spent by governments, donor and humanitarian organisations in advertisement and propaganda (Dietrich, Mahmud, and Winters, 2018; De Juan, Hofman, and Koos, 2023). Second, it is likely that for (humanitarian) aid to work as a tool for soft power, recipients need to correctly identify that the aid came from an international donor or government. Lastly, participants misattributing the source of the aid could even lead to outcomes opposite of those intended by the funder, for example, the strengthening of an oppressive or adversarial government (Guiteras and Mobarak, 2015; Cruz and Schneider, 2017). The intervention here is very light-touch, simply stating that the money came from an international donor (which participants associate as being the US, see Panel B of Figure 4) and the Pakistani government played no role in the project.

Given that the beliefs on the source of the funds are elicited twice in each survey, once at the beginning and once at the end of the survey, I can measure the effectiveness of the information intervention in correcting recipients’ beliefs about the source of the funds. Table 3 shows the results of this exercise. There are two outcomes of interest: Whether participants can correctly identify that the funds came from an international donor (odd columns) and their certainty in those beliefs (even columns). The Table includes data from only the first round of follow-up surveys, before any participant

received the information. When looking at the full sample in the first two columns, receiving the information about the source of the funds significantly increases the probability of correctly identifying that the donor was a foreigner by 43.7 percentage points, an increase of 120% relative to the mean in the group that did not receive this information. Participants are also more confident in their beliefs, increasing their certainty by 0.86 points (on a scale from 0 to 10), more than 10% of the mean in the control group.

Table 3: Effect of Information Provision on Beliefs & Certainty

	Baseline Beliefs on Source					
	All Sample		Not Int. Donor		Int. Donor	
	Guessed Int. Donor (1)	Certainty (0-10) (2)	Guessed Int. Donor (3)	Certainty (0-10) (4)	Guessed Int. Donor (5)	Certainty (0-10) (6)
Received Information	0.437*** (0.021)	0.860*** (0.132)	0.597*** (0.021)	1.176*** (0.169)	-0.014 (0.018)	0.012 (0.131)
Constant	0.362*** (0.018)	8.209*** (0.118)	0.150*** (0.016)	7.783*** (0.152)	0.965*** (0.014)	9.396*** (0.099)
Observations	2,024	1,999	1,504	1,480	518	518
R ²	0.205	0.083	0.336	0.098	0.013	0.058

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. Controlling for strata fixed effects. Odd columns show whether respondents correctly identify the identify of the funder (an international donor) at the end of the survey. Even columns show the certainty that respondents attach to their beliefs on the identify of the funder at the end of the survey. The first two columns look at the whole sample, the following two columns look at those who incorrectly believed at the beginning of the survey that the aid came from someone other than an international donor, and the last two columns look at those who correctly believed at the beginning of the survey that the aid came from an international donor.

Exploiting participants' responses at the beginning of the survey, I can analyse whether the effects concentrate among participants who initially believed the money did not come from an international donor, as expected. This is shown in columns 3 and 4. For these participants, the ones whose beliefs needed correction, the effects are much larger: The information increases the correct identification of the source of the funds by 59.7 percentage points, a 400% increase relative to the control mean. Their certainty also increases by 1.18 points, or 15% of the control mean. When looking at participants who correctly identified the donor to be foreign at the beginning of the survey in columns 5 and 6, and for whom we would thus expect no effect from providing this information, we see that this is indeed the case: There is no effect from providing the information on either the correct identification of the donor or their certainty.

These results show that the information provision intervention, despite being very light-touch, had a very large impact correcting participants' beliefs about the source of the funds, especially for those whose beliefs needed correction. Moreover, these effects persist over time: Table A1 presents the results using the answers to the questions at the beginning of the second round of surveys as outcomes. Despite an

average gap of 79 days between the first and the second round of follow-up surveys, receiving the information in the first round increases the probability of correctly identifying the donor as foreign by 11.7 percentage points, or over 20% of the sample mean.

5 Humanitarian Aid as Soft Power

Having established that the interventions achieved their goals of 1) addressing participants' humanitarian needs and 2) correcting their beliefs about the source of the funds, I now turn to the main research question of whether humanitarian aid can be used as a tool for soft power, by changing recipients' values, attitudes and political behaviours. There are three main soft power outcomes of interest: Views on foreign actors, values and attitudes, and political behaviours.

Given the 2×2 cross-randomised design, and to be able to disentangle whether what matters is the aid itself, the fact that it comes from a foreign donor, or the combination of both, I estimate the following regression:

$$y_{it} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Control}_i \times \text{Donor Information}_{it} + \beta_2 \text{Aid}_i \times \text{No Information}_{it} + \beta_3 \text{Aid}_i \times \text{Donor Information}_{it} + \psi_{it} + \varepsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

where y_{it} is the outcome of interest for participant i in survey round t . Control_i is a dummy that indicates whether the participant does not receive the humanitarian aid payments and is therefore part of the control group, while Aid_i indicates that the participant receives the humanitarian aid payments. $\text{No Information}_{it}$ is a dummy that indicates that the participant did not receive the information about the identity of the donor, while $\text{Donor Information}_{it}$ is a dummy that indicates that the participant received the information about the identity of the donor. ψ_{it} are strata and survey round fixed effects.⁵ I compute multiple-testing adjusted p -values following [Romano and Wolf \(2005\)](#), which are shown in square brackets. These are adjusted across the three relevant treatment arms, and for outcomes belonging to the same family and using the same sample, for consistency.

This analysis, along with the outcomes discussed below and the robustness checks, was pre-specified in a Pre-Analysis Plan registered at the AEA RCT Registry, trial number 0015121.

5.1 Views on Foreign Actors

Motivation & Measurement: At the most fundamental level, donors might want to use (humanitarian) aid as a way to improve their standing in the countries they operate. This has long been a goal behind soft power, and one of the most common con-

⁵I am not controlling for baseline values of these outcomes since most of these outcomes were not collected at baseline, as some are considered sensitive and the baseline was taken in the presence of other participants.

cerns with the recent retreat of aid has been that it would be detrimental to donors' image. For example, a recent article in the Council on Foreign Relations argues that "An overzealous effort at reforming USAID will dismantle programs that enhance U.S. security, save lives, and boost United States' image around the globe." ([Council on Foreign Relations, 2025](#)) This is important because improving the views of the donor in recipient countries can lead to less support for anti-donor activities in those countries, diplomatic leverage, and increased legitimacy for the work and interventions of the donor.

I focus on one particular aspect of participants' views on foreign actors: Whether they believe that the work of international organisations is helping Pakistan as a whole, and women like them in particular. This maps closely to the information intervention, in which participants are told that the aid came from an international organisation.

Results: Table ?? shows the results for these outcomes. In the first two columns, looking at the whole sample, we see that the three arms have a significant and positive effect on participants' views on the work of foreign organisations, both for Pakistan as a whole and for women like the participants. The effect for the former seems larger, although this difference is not statistically significant. Interestingly, this effect is present for those who receive the information but not the aid. This suggests that simply knowing that a foreign organisation is helping others in the community leads to improved views on the work of foreigners.

There is also an improvement in the views on foreigners for participants who receive the aid but not the information. This effect is entirely driven by those individuals who correctly identify that the donor is a foreign organisation, though. In columns 3 and 4, I focus on those who incorrectly believed the money came from someone other than an international donor. For those participants, receiving the aid only does not affect their views on foreign organisations.

Lastly, the effect is largest for those participants who receive both the aid and the information, since this combines two powerful signals: The fact that a foreign actor provided the aid, and the positive impact that this aid has on participants' lives (as discussed in Section 4.1). The effect is significantly larger than for those receiving either the information or the aid alone. Moreover, this combination succeeds in improving views of foreign actors, even among participants who initially believed the aid did not come from a foreign donor. This shows that the combination of aid and information about the source of the aid can meaningfully improve recipients' perceptions of foreign actors, a key objective of soft power.

5.2 Values & Attitudes

Motivation & Measurement: Beyond improving perceptions of donor countries, soft power fundamentally seeks to shape the values and worldviews of recipient popula-

Table 4: Effect on Support for International Organisations

	All Sample		Believes Non. Int. Donor	
	<i>Agrees Work of Interntional Organisations is Helping...</i>			
	Pakistan	Women Like Her	Pakistan	Women Like Her
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
β_1 : Control $\times$ Donor Info	0.033** (0.013) [0.011]	0.032** (0.014) [0.011]	0.008 (0.024) [0.964]	0.021 (0.025) [0.746]
β_2 : Received Aid $\times$ No Info	0.037*** (0.013) [0.006]	0.042*** (0.014) [0.004]	-0.009 (0.025) [0.964]	0.000 (0.027) [0.989]
β_3 : Received Aid $\times$ Donor Info	0.070*** (0.011) [0.001]	0.081*** (0.011) [0.001]	0.066*** (0.022) [0.008]	0.086*** (0.023) [0.001]
Constant	0.878*** (0.010)	0.872*** (0.010)	0.874*** (0.020)	0.860*** (0.021)
Observations	4,639	4,651	2,293	2,299
R^2	0.085	0.080	0.106	0.100
p -value $\beta_2 = \beta_3$	0.002	0	0	0

Notes: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Romano-Wolf multiple-testing adjusted p -values (Romano and Wolf, 2005), based on 1000 replications, are reported in square brackets, with adjustments applied jointly to Columns 1-2 and to Columns 3-4. Controlling for strata fixed effects and survey round fixed effects. At the bottom of the table, the p -value corresponds to a Wald test of the null hypothesis that the effect of receiving aid is the same with and without donor information. Columns 1 and 3 report results for the indicator of whether participants agree that the work of foreign organizations is helping Pakistan overall, while Columns 2 and 4 report results for the indicator of whether participants agree that the work is helping women like them. The first two columns use the full sample, whereas the last two restrict the sample to those who believed the aid was not from an international donor.

tions. For decades, Western donors have explicitly pursued value promotion through their aid programs, as evidenced by official policy documents and strategic goals. The [USAID Strategy on Democracy, Human Rights, and Governance \(2013\)](#) explicitly calls for promoting “human rights principles in accordance with universal values and international norms,” while the European Union frames its development cooperation as a means to “uphold and promote European values and interests” globally ([European Union, 2025](#)). This ideological dimension of aid represents a critical but understudied channel through which donors attempt to advance their interests – not merely by winning hearts and minds, but by fundamentally reshaping how recipients conceptualise fairness, cooperation, and social relations. This is particularly important since the global world order has been built upon the successful collaboration of people and nations with different cultures and principles, which can only be achieved if a certain alignment of values and ideologies exists.

While donor rhetoric often invokes broad concepts like “democratic values,” “market development” and “human dignity,” operationalising these abstract goals requires identifying specific, measurable dimensions of values that align with donor priorities. Market development, for instance, depends fundamentally on impersonal exchange – the ability to transact with strangers rather than relying solely on kinship networks. This requires populations to extend equal moral consideration to outsiders as they do to in-group members. Similarly, democratic participation requires citizens to view political competition as positive-sum rather than zero-sum, believing that one group’s political gains need not come at the expense of others. Both market and democratic institutions also rely on generalised social trust and the willingness to cooperate beyond clan or ethnic boundaries – extending respect and recognition across social divisions. These specific moral orientations – universalism, positive-sum thinking, and cross-group respect – represent the foundational values that must shift before broader institutional changes can take hold. Influencing these underlying moral frameworks is key to achieving the goals of donors in fostering democratic governance or market-based development.

To capture these dimensions comprehensively, I measure seven distinct but related aspects of values and attitudes, drawing from recent advances in economics. Following [Enke, Rodriguez-Padilla, and Zimmermann \(2022\)](#); [Cappelen, Enke, and Tungodden \(2025\)](#), I assess universalism – whether people are equally altruistic and trusting toward strangers as they are toward in-group members. This captures whether individuals can move beyond their own group, which is essential for impersonal market transactions and inclusive democratic participation. I examine whether participants believe it is their duty to help others in their communities, particularly the poor, reflecting the social solidarity that supports redistributive policies in democratic societies. To capture the tolerance needed for diverse societies to function peacefully, I measure whether participants believe in respecting people from all cultures, religions, and social groups. I also assess positive-sum thinking following [Chinoy et al. \(2025\)](#) – whether individuals believe that when one group gets richer or gains political power, it does not come at the expense of other groups. Those who support this positive-sum worldview are more likely to support market competition and democratic alternation of power. Together, these measures provide a comprehensive assessment of whether humanitarian aid, particularly when its foreign source is made salient, can shift deeply held values in directions aligned with donor priorities – moving recipients from particularistic, kinship-based moral frameworks toward the universalistic principles that undergird functioning markets and democracies.

Results: Table ?? shows the results looking at these outcomes. A few patterns emerge. First, for most outcomes, none of the three treatments (information alone, aid alone, or the combination of both) seems to have a significant effect. This lack of significant effects is not due to a lack of statistical precision: To the contrary, these are precisely

estimated null effects. For example, when looking at universalism or either measure of positive-sum thinking, the SEs on the coefficients would detect a significant effect at the 10% level of around 3% and 6% of the control mean, respectively, very small effects. The most likely explanation is that affecting something as fundamental as someone's values requires a stronger, longer-lasting intervention. This intervention only lasted for four months (and half the surveys come from when participants had received only one or two aid payments), and the information provision is very light touch.

Table 5: Effect on Values & Attitudes – All Sample

	Universalism (0-500) (1)	Strong Moral Duty Help Poor (2)	Responsible Others in Community (=1) (3)	Respect All Cultures & Beliefs (4)	Respect All Social Groups (5)	Positive-Sum Thinking Ethnicity (=1) (6)	Positive-Sum Thinking Income (=1) (7)
β_1 : Control $\times$ Donor Info	-3.558 (5.923) [0.993]	-0.008 (0.021) [0.993]	0.009 (0.012) [0.992]	-0.016 (0.020) [0.992]	-0.024 (0.018) [0.880]	-0.010 (0.022) [0.951]	0.002 (0.022) [0.993]
β_2 : Received Aid $\times$ No Info	4.192 (5.925) [0.993]	-0.008 (0.021) [0.993]	0.002 (0.012) [0.993]	0.024 (0.019) [0.922]	0.021 (0.017) [0.922]	-0.015 (0.022) [0.932]	0.012 (0.022) [0.951]
β_3 : Received Aid $\times$ Donor Info	-3.570 (5.069) [0.993]	0.012 (0.018) [0.993]	-0.004 (0.010) [0.993]	0.052*** (0.017) [0.022]	0.041*** (0.014) [0.055]	-0.001 (0.019) [0.993]	0.015 (0.019) [0.916]
Constant	283.764*** (4.012)	0.629*** (0.014)	0.083*** (0.008)	0.716*** (0.013)	0.801*** (0.012)	0.568*** (0.015)	0.557*** (0.015)
Observations	4,701	4,708	4,709	4,693	4,702	4,635	4,667
R^2	0.092	0.073	0.089	0.063	0.093	0.079	0.066
$\beta_2 = \beta_3$	0.145	0.291	0.566	0.118	0.182	0.467	0.891
$\beta_1 = \beta_3$	0.998	0.295	0.238	0.000	0.000	0.646	0.538

Notes: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Romano-Wolf multiple-testing adjusted p -values (Romano and Wolf, 2005), based on 1000 replications, are reported in square brackets, with adjustments applied jointly to Columns 1-5 and to Columns 6-7. Controlling for strata fixed effects and survey round fixed effects.

Column 1 reports allocations in the question, where the participant divides 500 PKR between a Pakistani stranger and a stranger from anywhere in the world (higher values indicate a greater allocation to the Pakistani stranger). Column 2 is an indicator for whether the participant agrees that the wealthy or strong have a moral duty to help the poor and weak. Column 3 is an indicator for whether the participant feels responsible for helping those outside their immediate family. Column 4 is an indicator for whether the participant believes in respecting all cultures and faiths. Column 5 is an indicator for whether the participant agrees that all social groups—men, women, rich, poor—deserve equal respect. Columns 6 and 7 report positive-sum thinking, namely whether the participant believe that when one group gains political power or gets richer, it does not come at the expense of other groups. Column 6 refers to the former, and Column 7 to the latter (indicator = 1 if the participant disagrees with the zero-sum statement).

Second, and related to that point, the only significant effects come from the strongest treatment, receiving both the aid and the information. This combination has a positive and significant effect on participants' respect towards individuals from other cultures and beliefs (column 4) or from other social groups (column 5). The effect sizes are small, however. Respect towards people from other cultures and beliefs increases by 5.2 percentage points, or $\sim 7\%$ of the control mean, while respect towards people from all social groups increases by 4.1 percentage points, or $\sim 5\%$ of the control mean.

5.3 Political Behaviours

Motivation & Measurement: Perhaps the most ambitious aspect of soft power through aid is influencing political behaviours in recipient countries. Historical examples demonstrate this long-standing goal: Diplomatic pressure during the Marshall Plan era led to the exclusion of Communist parties from government coalitions in countries like

France and Italy. More recently, a progress report shared with USAID and State Department officials highlighted how “public outreach is integrated into the design of each project to highlight the role of the Palestinian Authority in meeting citizens needs” with “events running every day... such that there is a constant stream of announcements and public outreach about positive happenings all over Palestinian areas in the critical week before the elections” (Faye and Niehaus, 2012). Such political influence, if achievable through humanitarian aid, would provide donors with a valuable geo-economic tool to shape outcomes in recipient countries – whether strengthening allied governments or catalysing change in hostile environments.

I comprehensively measure different types of political behaviours, reflecting the varying costs and constraints of political engagement for vulnerable women in Pakistan. At the most basic level, I use self-reported measures of government satisfaction, effectiveness, and legitimacy. Given the concerns regarding self-reported survey questions, I also use two lab-in-the-field games that provide incentivised measures of participants’ views on the government’s effectiveness and legitimacy (Acemoglu et al., 2020; Blair, Marty, and Roessler, 2022). These attitudinal measures represent a key outcome of interest for soft power and the most malleable aspects of political opinion and perception.

I examine political participation, a costlier type of political outcomes, at two levels: within-household actions (such as asking family members to raise community issues with leaders) and outside-household engagement (including participation in women’s groups addressing political concerns). This distinction is crucial given the severe mobility and autonomy constraints facing women in Pakistan, where even indirect political participation through male family members represents meaningful engagement. Finally, I include a real-world measure of costly political action: willingness to sign a public petition advocating for greater women’s rights in the local area. Participants are informed that their names would appear publicly if they choose to sign, making this a credible signal of political commitment.⁶

This graduated approach – from private attitudes through household influence to public political action – allows me to identify precisely where the effects of humanitarian aid reach their limits. While aid might shift satisfaction or perceptions, influencing costly political behaviours represents a more stringent test of soft power’s reach, particularly given the brief four-month intervention period and the profound constraints on women’s political agency in this context, something that was highlighted in the pre-analysis plan.

Views on Government: The first set of outcomes concerns participants’ perception of the government. Table 6 shows the results. The first five columns examine outcomes

⁶In reality, their names were not made publicly available, nor was there a petition. This was included in the IRB applications.

related to participants' attitudes toward the government, while the last three columns assess the legitimacy of various government components. It is important to note that government effectiveness/satisfaction and legitimacy, while related, are fundamentally different and capture distinct concepts. Effectiveness and satisfaction concern the government's ability to provide services, execute projects and steer the country in the right direction, while legitimacy concerns people's willingness to obey authorities and comply with government regulations and laws (Levi, Sacks, and Tyler, 2009).

In terms of attitudes, the results suggest that receiving the information alone does not affect these outcomes. Receiving the aid alone has a positive, but mostly insignificant, effect on these outcomes: The aid seems to increase participants' perceptions of government effectiveness in providing services, and the overall index combining these outcomes increases by 0.076σ (significant at the 10% level). The strongest effect comes from receiving both the information and the aid: This combination improves participants' perceptions of the government's effectiveness, increases their satisfaction with the government, and makes them more likely to believe that the government is going in the right direction. Combined, there is an improvement in the index combining these outcomes of 0.125σ , a sizable effect. This sounds counterintuitive: Why would being told that a foreign donor provided assistance improve recipients' perceptions of the national government? While the mechanisms are discussed in detail below, this combination appears to convey a positive signal to participants about the country's future, which they attribute to the government.

Table 6: Effect on Political Attitudes & Legitimacy

	Attitudes					Legitimacy		
	Gov. Effective Providing Services (1)	Trust National Government (2)	Satisfaction with Nat. Gov. (3)	Gov. Going Right Direction (4)	Anderson Index (5)	Gov. Authority Make People Pay Taxes (6)	Police Right Make People Obey Law (7)	Courts Right Make Decisions People Abide to (8)
β_1 : Control $\times$ Donor Info	-0.022 (0.022) [0.743]	0.008 (0.022) [0.935]	0.029 (0.022) [0.614]	-0.005 (0.019) [0.950]	-0.001 (0.044) [0.990]	-0.006 (0.022) [1.000]	-0.012 (0.020) [0.987]	0.002 (0.018) [1.000]
β_2 : Received Aid $\times$ No Info	0.055** (0.022) [0.102]	0.019 (0.022) [0.751]	0.033 (0.022) [0.511]	0.021 (0.020) [0.743]	0.076* (0.044) [0.387]	0.025 (0.022) [0.879]	0.006 (0.020) [1.000]	-0.001 (0.018) [1.000]
β_3 : Received Aid $\times$ Donor Info	0.063*** (0.019) [0.007]	0.025 (0.018) [0.614]	0.061*** (0.018) [0.007]	0.041** (0.017) [0.114]	0.125*** (0.037) [0.007]	0.014 (0.019) [0.982]	0.003 (0.017) [1.000]	0.011 (0.015) [0.982]
Constant	0.519*** (0.015)	0.586*** (0.015)	0.575*** (0.015)	0.255*** (0.013)	0.005 (0.029)	0.426*** (0.015)	0.716*** (0.013)	0.803*** (0.012)
Observations	4,706	4,717	4,718	4,634	4,725	4,660	4,694	4,687
R^2	0.058	0.059	0.071	0.050	0.073	0.055	0.061	0.062
p -value $\beta_2 = \beta_3$	0.693	0.782	0.159	0.283	0.225	0.591	0.858	0.449

Notes: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Romano-Wolf multiple-testing adjusted p -values (Romano and Wolf, 2005), based on 5000 replications, are reported in square brackets, with adjustments applied jointly to Columns 1-5 and to Columns 6-8. Controlling for strata fixed effects and survey round fixed effects.

Column 1 is an indicator that is one if the participant finds the current national government effective in providing services to the average person. Column 2 is an indicator for whether the participant trusts the current national government. Column 3 is an indicator for whether the participant is satisfied with the current national government. Column 4 is an indicator for whether the participant believes the Government of Pakistan is going in the right direction. Column 5 is the Anderson (2008) index combining Columns 1-4. Column 6 is an indicator for whether the participant agrees that the government's tax authorities always have the right to make people pay taxes. Column 7 is an indicator for whether the participant agrees that the police always have the right to enforce the law. Column 8 is an indicator for whether the participant agrees that courts always have the right to make decisions that people are required to obey. Columns 1-5 present the effects on recipients' attitudes towards the government. Columns 6-8 present the effects on recipients' beliefs about the legitimacy of different government institutions.

In terms of legitimacy, participants' perceptions of the government's legitimacy to raise taxes, enforce the law through the police, and courts making decisions that citizens must abide by remain unchanged across the three groups. The combination of the aid and the information improves their perception of the government's effectiveness, but not its legitimacy.

Lab Games: Given the self-reported nature of the measures in the previous section, there are concerns that people might be answering in a non-truthful way, especially considering the sensitive nature of some of these questions. To overcome these concerns, I employ two lab-in-the-field games. One, used by [Acemoglu et al. \(2020\)](#) in Pakistan, aims at measuring government's effectiveness, while the other, used by [Blair, Marty, and Roessler \(2022\)](#) in Sierra Leone, aims at measuring government's legitimacy. Here, I provide a brief overview of the games' mechanics and their motivation, with a complete description of the games' protocols provided in Online Appendix E.

In the first game, the Government Fund Game, participants receive an endowment of 500 PKR (~2 USD). They then decide how much of this endowment they keep for themselves, and how much they give to a government fund. They are told that any money allocated to the government fund will be doubled and given to the government "to be used for local programs in your community".⁷ Thus, participants will allocate more money to the government fund if they believe that the government will actually spend their funds in an effective manner in these local programs in their community.

In the second game, the Income Reporting Game, participants again receive an endowment of 500 PKR ("income"). They then need to decide how much of this income to report to the government, and how much not to report to the government. Any income reported to the government is taxed at a 25% rate, as would be the case with income taxation. If participants do not report part of their income, there is a 10% probability that they are audited. If they are audited, they receive a penalty of 50% of the income they did not report. Participants are told that the tax/penalty income collected in the game will actually be sent to the government.⁸ These values are not calibrated to match real-world rates but to make computations easier for participants. The idea here is that participants will report a higher share of their income if they believe the government to be legitimate, as they are complying with the rules of the government (paying taxes).

For each of the two games, participants play a practice round where surveyors walk them through the games in detail (participants' understanding of the games, asked using four comprehension questions after the practice rounds, is very high, as

⁷The endowment given to the government is doubled to give an incentive to participants to give to the government fund.

⁸In practice, implementing sending money from the games to the government was impossible in the pilots. At the moment of writing, we are looking to donate this money to NGOs conducting local development programs in these districts.

seen in Table A2), and then they play two real rounds. For each game, they also play a non-political version of the game (for the Government Fund game, it is giving to a local sports club; for the Income Reporting game, it is reporting profits to an NGO). The information provision intervention takes place between the two real rounds of the games. This setup has two important advantages: First, the same games are played just before and immediately after the information is provided. Second, given the multiple rounds, it is possible to add individual fixed effects to the regressions, controlling for any individual-specific factors that remain constant across game rounds. Thus, for the games, I estimate the following regression:

$$y_{ir} = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 \text{Received Aid}_i + \gamma_2 \text{Donor Information (Between Rounds)}_{ir} + \gamma_3 \text{Received Aid}_i \times \text{Donor Information (Between Rounds)}_{ir} + \omega_{ir} + v_{ir} \quad (2)$$

where y_{ir} is the outcome of interest for participant i in game round r . Received Aid_i indicates that the participant receives the humanitarian aid payments. $\text{Donor Information (Between Rounds)}_{ir}$ is a dummy that indicates that the participant received the information about the identity of the donor between the two rounds of the games. ω_{ir} are strata, survey round, and game round fixed effects, as well as participants giving in the non-political versions of the games (to control for the mechanical income effect coming from the fact that the treatment involved giving participants money) and for the Income Reporting Game a dummy for whether they were audited in a previous round. When individual fixed effects are included, γ_1 isn't estimated, as this is time-invariant.

The games' results are shown in Table 7. The first four columns show the results for the Government Fund Game, and the last four for the Income Reporting Game. For each game, results are shown for the entire sample (first two columns) and for the sample that initially believed the aid did not come from an international donor (last two columns). Odd columns don't include individual fixed effects, while even columns include individual fixed effects.

The results for the Government Fund Game mirror those obtained using the self-reported measures: The combination of aid and information significantly and substantially increases giving to the Government Fund. This holds even when exploiting only within-individual variation. The combination leads to 5.64 PKR more given to the Government Fund (column 2), or ~20% of the control mean. These effects are concentrated among participants who wrongly believed the money did not come from an international donor (columns 3 and 4).

Similarly, the results for the Income Reporting Game mirror those when using self-reported measures of legitimacy: Neither the aid, nor the information, nor the combination of these has a significant effect on participants' income reported to the government.

Table 7: Lab Games Outcomes (500 PKR Endowment Each)

	Government Fund Game (Effectiveness)				Income Reporting Game (Legitimacy)			
	All Sample (1)	(2)	Wrong Beliefs (3)	(4)	All Sample (5)	(6)	Wrong Beliefs (7)	(8)
γ_1 : Received Aid	-0.118 (0.917) [1.000]		-2.989** (1.460) [0.148]		0.438 (3.293) [1.000]		0.401 (5.373) [0.987]	
γ_2 : Donor Info (Between Rounds)	-1.976 (1.632) [0.643]	-2.018 (1.691) [0.019]	-3.295 (2.380) [0.467]	-2.108 (2.333) [0.110]	0.524 (4.925) [1.000]	-5.438 (5.378) [0.037]	1.075 (7.808) [0.987]	0.224 (7.775) [0.998]
γ_3 : Received Aid $\times$ Donor Info	6.435*** (1.851) [0.006]	5.642*** (1.811) [0.001]	7.990*** (2.665) [0.010]	7.277*** (2.360) [0.001]	-2.905 (5.887) [0.961]	0.687 (5.773) [0.779]	-2.934 (8.622) [0.966]	-0.243 (7.566) [0.998]
Constant	17.560*** (0.899)	28.074*** (1.226)	19.257*** (1.558)	32.698*** (2.637)	34.768*** (2.530)	57.236*** (3.104)	40.336*** (4.632)	67.273*** (5.432)
Observations	9,454	9,454	4,700	4,700	9,400	9,398	4,669	4,659
R^2	0.594	0.771	0.592	0.822	0.626	0.809	0.549	0.848
Rounds 1+2 Data	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Individual Fixed Effects	×	✓	×	✓	×	✓	×	✓
$\gamma_2 + \gamma_3$	4.459***	3.623***	4.696**	5.169**	-2.381	-4.751	-1.859	-0.019

Notes: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Romano-Wolf multiple-testing adjusted p -values (Romano and Wolf, 2005), based on 5000 replications, are reported in square brackets, with adjustments applied jointly to Columns 1 and 5, Columns 2 and 6, Columns 3 and 7, and Columns 4 and 8. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Controlling for strata fixed effects (BISP receipt), survey round fixed effects, and game round fixed effects. For government fund game, controlling for giving to sports fund. For reported income game, controlling for income reported to NGO and whether participant has been audited in previous round.

Columns 1-4 present results for the government fund game, where each column shows the amount of the 500 PKR endowment that a participant allocates to the government fund. Columns 5-8 report results for the reported income game, where each column shows the amount of the 500 PKR income that a participant chooses to disclose to the government for a 25% tax. Within each set, the first two columns present the full sample, while the other two focus on participants who incorrectly believed the aid did not come from an international donor, with even-numbered columns including individual fixed effects.

Overall, the results using the incentivised measures of government effectiveness and legitimacy mimic those from the self-reported measures: The combination of the aid and the information improves participants views of the government, particularly its effectiveness, while not affecting its legitimacy.

Political Participation & Actions: Having analysed participants' views and opinions towards the government, I now turn to three costlier types of political behaviours. The results are presented in Table 8. The first three columns look at participants' political participation within their households. In particular, I look at whether participants have tried to influence a male household member to raise or act on a community issue (column 1) or encouraged another household member to attend a community meeting (column 2). Given the mobility and political constraints women face in these communities, these are more likely ways in which they could express their political opinions. Column 3 shows an index summarising these measures. Columns 4 to 8 look at participants' participation outside the household, including speaking to a local leader about a community issue (column 4), participating in a women's group (column 5), contributing resources to a community initiative (column 6) or helping mobilise women (column 7), with a summary index in column 8. The last column looks at a real, costly political action: Participants were asked whether they agreed to sign a petition by a local NGO

asking for more rights for women in their community. If they agreed, then their names would be made publicly available. This represents actual behaviour that can be captured in the survey, rather than self-reported political participation.

Table 8: Effect on Political Participation Outcomes – All Sample

	Inside HH			Outside HH				Actual Behavior	
	Influenced Male Member Raise Issue (1)	Encouraged HH Member Attend Meeting (2)	Anderson Index (3)	Spoke Local Leader Issues (4)	Participated Women's Group (5)	Contributed Resources Comm. Initiative (6)	Helped Organise Women (7)	Anderson Index (8)	Signed Petition Asking Rights (9)
β_1 : Control $\times$ Donor Info	0.013 (0.014) [0.996]	-0.003 (0.013) [1.000]	0.018 (0.044) [1.000]	0.011 (0.012) [0.994]	-0.008 (0.008) [0.991]	-0.006 (0.016) [1.000]	0.030* (0.016) [0.692]	0.017 (0.044) [1.000]	0.037* (0.020) [0.692]
β_2 : Received Aid $\times$ No Info	0.006 (0.013) [1.000]	0.010 (0.013) [1.000]	0.030 (0.046) [1.000]	0.003 (0.012) [1.000]	-0.018** (0.008) [0.332]	0.015 (0.016) [0.995]	0.013 (0.016) [1.000]	-0.016 (0.041) [1.000]	0.017 (0.020) [1.000]
β_3 : Received Aid $\times$ Donor Info	-0.001 (0.011) [1.000]	0.001 (0.011) [1.000]	-0.001 (0.037) [1.000]	-0.002 (0.010) [1.000]	-0.011 (0.007) [0.854]	0.006 (0.014) [1.000]	0.007 (0.014) [1.000]	-0.019 (0.037) [1.000]	0.031* (0.017) [0.696]
Constant	0.099*** (0.009)	0.090*** (0.008)	-0.010 (0.029)	0.073*** (0.008)	0.041*** (0.006)	0.160*** (0.011)	0.151*** (0.010)	-0.011 (0.029)	0.606*** (0.014)
Observations	4,724	4,726	4,726	4,722	4,724	4,724	4,722	4,726	4,716
R^2	0.035	0.036	0.040	0.030	0.040	0.057	0.047	0.050	0.164
$\beta_2 = \beta_3$	0.565	0.451	0.457	0.642	0.292	0.551	0.668	0.930	0.448
$\beta_1 = \beta_3$	0.270	0.730	0.628	0.228	0.738	0.417	0.132	0.354	0.745

Notes: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Romano-Wolf multiple-testing adjusted p -values (Romano and Wolf, 2005) based on 5000 replications are reported in square brackets. Controlling for strata fixed effects and survey round fixed effects.

Columns 1-3 measure political participation inside the household. Column 1 indicates whether the participant tried to influence a male family member (husband, father, brother) to raise or act on a community issue. Column 2 indicates whether the participant encouraged or helped a household member to attend a community meeting or take action on a community issue. Column 3 is the Anderson (2008) index combining Columns 1 and 2.

Columns 4-8 measure political participation outside the household. Column 4 indicates whether the participant spoke to a local leader (e.g., neighborhood elder, religious scholar, social worker) about issues affecting the community. Column 5 indicates whether the participant participated in a women's group, community organisation, or political platform to address challenges faced by women. Column 6 indicates whether the participant contributed resources (money, food, or labor) to support a community initiative, even if not directly participating. Column 7 indicates whether the participant helped other women in the community by sharing information, organising meetings, or encouraging their participation. Column 8 is the Anderson (2008) index combining Columns 4-7. Column 9 indicates whether the participant agreed to sign a petition by a local NGO asking for more rights for women in the community.

Overall, the results suggest that neither the aid, nor the information, nor the combination of both affects participants' political participation, either inside or outside their households. These are precisely-estimated null effects: The SEs on the indices for political participation inside and outside the household would pick up effects of around 0.065σ at the 10% level, around half the effect of what was observed for the aid plus information group in terms of the political attitudes index. Receiving the information or the combination of the aid and the information does lead to significant increases in signing the petition, but the effects are small and only marginally significant. In the PAP, I pre-specified that it was unlikely these outcomes would change, given the short-term nature of the aid and the light-touch approach to the information intervention. It is difficult to tell whether the lack of effects is due to the constraints that women in these communities face, the intervention itself, or truly a lack of effect of humanitarian aid on recipients' political participation.

Mechanisms: The results so far indicate that the combination of the aid and the information about the fact that the donor is foreign improves participants' views on the government, in particular its effectiveness. These results are confirmed using both self-

reported survey measures and incentivised lab game outcomes. This can appear counterintuitive: Why would telling people that the aid came from an international donor increase support for the *national government*? In this Section, I discuss potential mechanisms that could explain this puzzling result.

One reason could be that the participants (wrongly) credit the government for the aid, and hence become more positive about the government after receiving the aid. In fact, the literature has found that development programs are prone to credit capture and misattribution (see, e.g., [Guiteras and Mobarak, 2015](#); [Cruz and Schneider, 2017](#)). However, this is unlikely to be the case for a few reasons. First, the information explicitly states that “the Pakistani government played no role in this project”, and the results in Table 3 show that the intervention succeeded in correcting participants’ beliefs about the source of the funds. Second, the effects are present among both the participants who wrongly believed the aid did not come from an international donor, and those who correctly believed the aid came from an international donor. Third, if the results were due to misattribution, we would see an effect among the participants who received the aid but not the information, which doesn’t seem to be the case. Thus, credit misattribution seems unlikely to explain the results.

Another potential explanation is that participants’ lives are better because of the aid (as shown in Table 2), and this makes them, in general, more positive towards the government. However, this also does not seem to be the case: If this were the case, then participants who receive the aid but not the information (whose lives improved the same as those receiving the combination) would also show a similar improvement in their views towards the government. However, this is not the case.

The mechanism seems to be something more subtle: The combination of aid and information appears to operate through a signalling mechanism about Pakistan’s institutional trajectory. When recipients learn that international organisations are actively operating in Pakistan, this conveys important information beyond the immediate humanitarian assistance. In fragile states, the presence of international organisations – not just humanitarian actors who often work in the most challenging contexts – signals a level of stability and opportunity that recipients cannot easily observe themselves. International organisations undertake careful assessments of political risk, security, and operational feasibility before committing resources. Their willingness to invest and operate in Pakistan thus serves as a positive signal that the country maintains sufficient governance capacity and future prospects to merit international engagement. This presence suggests that external actors view Pakistan as a place where meaningful work can be accomplished, not merely as a site of irreversible state failure.

The aid component is crucial for this mechanism because it transforms cheap talk into costly action. While information alone might be dismissed as propaganda or empty promises, the actual delivery of resources – which significantly improved recipients’ lives – demonstrates that international actors are not merely expressing op-

timism but are backing their assessments with concrete investments. This distinction matters particularly in contexts where citizens have extensive experience with unfulfilled promises from both domestic and international actors. The successful delivery of aid through formal channels, even without government involvement, may signal that Pakistan’s institutional infrastructure – banking systems, telecommunications, and basic security – remains functional enough to support development activities.

Table 9 shows evidence in support of this mechanism, which shows that the combined treatment specifically enhances optimism about future political institutions. The first two columns look at the whole sample, while the last two include only those participants who believed the aid did not come from an international donor. The outcome in the odd columns is participants’ likelihood that the political system will change in the next two years (from 0 to 10), and in the even columns, whether participants believe the political system will be better for women like them in the next two years. Recipients appear to update their beliefs about Pakistan’s trajectory: Participants who receive the aid plus the information are significantly more likely to believe that the political system will change in the next two years (column 1), and in particular to improve for women like her (column 2). The effects are also sizable: The likelihood of political change increases by 0.48 points (13% of the control mean) while the feeling that this will be better for women like them increases by 6.4 percentage points (12% of the control mean).

The group receiving only the aid also sees an increase in the probability of change to the political system, but as columns 3 and 4 show, this effect is concentrated among participants who correctly identified the donor to be foreign. Moreover, the combination of the aid and the information is particularly effective in increasing these outcomes among participants who initially believed the aid did not come from an international donor, and hence for whom the information corrects these beliefs.

The intervention thus appears to shift expectations about Pakistan’s institutional trajectory through the signal of sustained international engagement. Recipients interpret foreign organisations’ willingness to operate in Pakistan as evidence that the country maintains viable prospects, updating their beliefs about where Pakistan is headed. This manifests in increased optimism about future political change and greater willingness to invest in government programs that might yield future returns. Yet, these same recipients show no change in state legitimacy—their sense of obligation to pay taxes or obey authorities remains unchanged. This divergence likely reflects that effectiveness and legitimacy represent fundamentally different aspects of state assessment. While effectiveness concerns whether the state can deliver, legitimacy concerns whether it has the right to rule. The presence of international actors may credibly signal improving state capacity and future prospects, but cannot speak to questions of rightful authority that emerge from the relationship between state and citizens. The intervention essentially provides new information about Pakistan’s international standing

Table 9: Effect on Beliefs on Political Institutions

	All Sample		Believes Non. Int. Donor	
	Views on the Political System in Pakistan (Next 2 Years)			
	Likelihood of Change (0-10) (1)	Improve For Women Like Her (=1) (2)	Likelihood of Change (0-10) (3)	Improve For Women Like Her (=1) (4)
β_1 : Control $\times$ Donor Info	0.207 (0.145) [0.320]	0.007 (0.022) [0.758]	0.417* (0.237) [0.192]	0.045 (0.037) [0.314]
β_2 : Received Aid $\times$ No Info	0.430*** (0.144) [0.007]	0.015 (0.023) [0.740]	0.374 (0.243) [0.251]	0.039 (0.039) [0.314]
β_3 : Received Aid $\times$ Donor Info	0.476*** (0.123) [0.003]	0.064*** (0.019) [0.004]	0.531** (0.220) [0.057]	0.093*** (0.034) [0.032]
Constant	3.595*** (0.096)	0.517*** (0.015)	3.376*** (0.193)	0.492*** (0.031)
Observations	4,602	4,600	2,283	2,276
R^2	0.068	0.058	0.063	0.061
p -value $\beta_2 = \beta_3$	0.729	0.016	0.389	0.056

Notes: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Romano-Wolf multiple-testing adjusted p -values (Romano and Wolf, 2005), based on 5000 replications, are reported in square brackets, with adjustments applied jointly to Columns 1-2 and to Columns 3-4. Controlling for strata fixed effects and survey round fixed effects. At the bottom of the table, the p -value corresponds to a Wald test of the null hypothesis that the effect of receiving aid is the same with and without donor information. Columns 1-2 use the full sample. Columns 3-4 restrict the sample to participants who believed the aid did not come from an international donor. Columns 1 and 3 report effects on the perceived likelihood that the political system in Pakistan will change substantially in the next two years (0-10 scale). Columns 2 and 4 report effects on whether participants believe the political system will improve for women like them over the next two years.

that shapes forward-looking expectations without altering core beliefs about political obligation.

Overall, the results in this Section suggest that humanitarian aid can serve as a tool for soft power, especially when coupled with information about the donor. This combination of aid and information improves recipients' views on the work of foreign organisations in Pakistan and their perceptions of the domestic government, by providing a positive signal about the country's institutional future. While more subdued, it also appears to foster greater respect towards individuals from different cultures and social groups.

6 Robustness Checks

6.1 Experimenter Demand Effects

One concern might be that of experimenter demand effects, or people answering in a certain way to "please" the surveyors. There are two different types of experimenter demand effects that may be present. First, there could be strategic answering by the control group, for example, by reporting that their situation is worse than it really is, in an attempt to qualify for the aid payments. Second, there could be strategic answer-

ing by the treatment group, for example, to make sure that they don't lose their aid payments.

Several factors reduce concerns about either sort of strategic answering. First, among the sample that is aware of the humanitarian program, everyone is told clearly at the registration point that 1) only 2/3 of participants would receive the aid payments, and 2) there was nothing they could do to change their status, to set expectations right from the beginning. Still, some participants might not believe that to be the case and could still have altered their responses. Thus, I set aside another control group that does not participate in the registration sessions and is therefore unaware of the humanitarian program's existence, as described briefly in Section 3 and in detail in Online Appendix C. By comparing the answers of this "pure control" group to those of the control group that knows about the program and may have an incentive to alter their answers in a particular way, I can assess whether experimenter demand effects are a concern among the control group.

I pre-specified this experimenter demand effects test in the PAP, and the results are presented in Table 10. It shows the results of the pre-specified outcomes for this test: the indices of three main humanitarian outcomes (which one would expect to be the most prone to suffer from experimenter demand effects), and the lab-in-the-field outcomes, both in the first round and combining game rounds. The sample includes only those individuals in the pure control group and in the control group that attended the onboarding sessions. As can be seen, there seem to be no statistically significant differences between the two groups, allaying concerns of strategic answering in the control group.

Table 10: Experimenter Demand – Pre-Specified Test

	Humanitarian Outcomes			Lab Games					
	Nutritional Diversity (1)	Food Security (2)	Mental Wellbeing (3)	Round 1		Rounds 1 + 2			
				Taxation Game (4)	Government Fund (5)	Taxation Game (6)	Taxation Game (7)	Government Fund (8)	Government Fund (9)
α_1 : Pure Control	-0.360 (0.546)	-0.008 (0.045)	-0.062 (0.045)	-4.018 (6.259)	-0.976 (1.749)	-4.867 (4.576)	-3.677 (4.154)	-1.103 (1.381)	-0.161 (1.274)
Reported Income NGO				0.710*** (0.018)		0.736*** (0.014)	0.751*** (0.012)		
Giving Sports Fund					0.818*** (0.028)			0.804*** (0.022)	0.780*** (0.028)
Audited in Previous Round				20.812** (9.619)		21.544*** (5.835)	18.751*** (4.942)	4.497** (2.087)	5.806*** (1.783)
Constant	34.457*** (0.319)	0.003 (0.027)	0.021 (0.026)	61.727*** (5.389)	21.113*** (1.665)	54.460*** (4.351)	50.015*** (3.541)	20.466*** (1.371)	20.504*** (1.494)
Observations	2,030	2,030	2,030	2,014	2,030	3,126	4,018	3,157	4,060
R^2	0.116	0.090	0.117	0.625	0.637	0.660	0.674	0.659	0.640
Round 1 Data				✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Round 2 Data				×	×	✓	✓	✓	✓
Including Info. Sample						×	✓	×	✓

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. Controlling for strata fixed effects and survey round fixed effects.

While I do not conduct a test of experimenter demand effects for the treatment group, several pieces of evidence suggest that this is unlikely to be a concern here. First,

those participants are already receiving their aid payments, so they have less of an incentive to manipulate their answers. Second, for the outcomes of interest in this study (values and political behaviours), it is difficult to reconcile the results with respondents trying to satisfy surveyors or researchers (e.g. the aid seems to make treated women *more* pro-government, even when they are explicitly told that the Pakistani government played no role in the aid and it came from an international donor). Third, in a related study conducted with a similar sample in Afghanistan ([Callen et al., 2025](#)), we conducted a rigorous test of experimenter demand effects among all treatment arms following [De Quidt, Haushofer, and Roth \(2018\)](#), and found no evidence of this.

6.2 Lab-in-the-field Games Comprehension

The lab-in-the-field games can, in principle, seem difficult for participants, especially considering the low education levels in the sample. This could raise concerns about participants' understanding of the games and their answers.

To address these concerns, the games were extensively piloted in three small-scale pilots conducted prior to the intervention, to create a set of guidelines and best practices for the games. The surveyors of the main intervention underwent four days of training, with a particular focus on the games, before the rollout of the intervention. During the surveys, participants played a practice round in which they were walked through the instructions step by step, and their questions were answered.

Table [A2](#) shows that the understanding of the lab-in-the-field games is high. For each game, four comprehension questions were asked at the end of the practice rounds. If participants answered a question wrong, they would receive a short explanation of the correct answer. On average, participants answered 3.85 about the Government Fund game correctly, and 3.57 about the Income Reporting Game.⁹ The lab-game results are robust to excluding participants who have a low understanding (i.e. those who get at least 3 out of the 4 questions for each game correctly), as seen in Table [A3](#).

6.3 Balance & Attrition

The different treatment arms are largely balanced. Table [A4](#) shows the balance among pre-specified heterogeneity (Panel A) and outcome variables (Panel B), at baseline (given that no baseline was collected for the pure control group, this group is excluded). The Table compares these outcomes for 1) the whole control group (regardless of information treatment assignment), 2) the group receiving the aid but not the information, and 3) the group receiving both the aid and the information. Means are shown in columns 2 to 5, p -values of pairwise comparisons in columns 6 to 8, and omnibus tests in column 9 and the last row. Overall, except for being the head of the

⁹The same holds when looking at each survey round individually, as participants might get better in the second survey round due to more experience.

household (which is slightly higher in the control group), all groups appear similar in these characteristics.

Attrition is also very low, as shown in Table [A6](#). Of 4930 possible surveys across two rounds, 4727 were completed, a survey completion rate of 96%. Attrition was slightly higher in the second round of surveys (111 missing surveys versus 92 in the first round) due to flood threats during the last week of surveys. Most attrition comes from participants being unreachable (175, e.g., due to being out of the district or difficulties in locating them) rather than refusing to be surveyed (28, of which seven are partially completed surveys). While individuals in the cash treatment group are significantly less likely to attrit than those in the control group, this difference is not meaningful (23 more participants attrited in the control group than in the cash treatment group).

7 Conclusion

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Online Appendix

A Additional Tables & Figures

Table A1: Persistence Information Provision on Beliefs & Certainty

	Round 1 Baseline Beliefs on Source					
	All Sample		Not Int. Donor		Int. Donor	
	Guessed Int. Donor (1)	Certainty (0-10) (2)	Guessed Int. Donor (3)	Certainty (0-10) (4)	Guessed Int. Donor (5)	Certainty (0-10) (6)
Received Information	0.117*** (0.023)	0.074 (0.129)	0.149*** (0.027)	0.123 (0.157)	0.028 (0.045)	-0.018 (0.224)
Constant	0.503*** (0.019)	8.798*** (0.107)	0.466*** (0.023)	8.706*** (0.130)	0.632*** (0.037)	9.099*** (0.184)
Observations	2,021	1,999	1,468	1,450	506	505
R^2	0.033	0.028	0.042	0.037	0.025	0.017

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. Controlling for strata fixed effects. Odd columns show whether respondents correctly identify the identify of the funder (an international donor) at the beginning of the second round survey. Even columns show the certainty that respondents attach to their beliefs on the identify of the funder at the beginning of the second round survey. Sample restricted to second round of survey. The first two columns look at the whole sample, the following two columns look at those who incorrectly believed at the beginning of the first round survey that the aid came from someone other than an international donor, and the last two columns look at those who correctly believed at the beginning of the first round survey that the aid came from an international donor.

ONLINE APPENDIX

Table A2: Share of Correct Questions in Games' Comprehension Questions

	Overall (1)	Control (2)	Treated (3)	<i>p</i> -value (4)
Panel A. Fund Game				
Q1. # of Funds	97.85	97.66	97.99	.551
Q2. Income Available	95.16	95.39	94.98	.488
Q3. Gov. Gets if 100 PKR Donated	94.36	93.46	95.03	.062
Q4. Sports Club Gets if 100 PKR Donated	97.28	96.4	97.94	.008
Total Correct Fund Game	3.85	3.83	3.86	.114
Panel B. Income Reporting Game				
Q1. Income Available	96.28	95.73	96.69	.153
Q2. Taxes Per 100 PKR Reported	86.45	86.25	86.6	.837
Q3. Share Black Beans (Audit)	89.43	89.12	89.66	.7
Q4. Penalty if Black Bean	85.01	83.58	86.09	.039
Total Correct Tax Compliance Game	3.57	3.55	3.59	.139

Notes: *p*-value estimated controlling for stratification fixed effects, and with robust standard errors. Those who don't answer the question are marked as having answered wrong.

Table A3: Lab Games Outcomes (500 PKR Endowment Each) – Excluding Those with Low Understanding

	Government Fund Game (Effectiveness)				Income Reporting Game (Legitimacy)			
	All Sample (1)	(2)	Wrong Beliefs (3)	(4)	All Sample (5)	(6)	Wrong Beliefs (7)	(8)
γ_1 : Received Aid	-0.398 (0.920)		-3.699** (1.471)		0.219 (3.453)		-0.064 (5.732)	
γ_2 : Donor Info (Between Rounds)	-1.919 (1.647)	-2.151 (1.711)	-3.321 (2.406)	-2.132 (2.375)	0.815 (5.211)	-4.688 (5.704)	0.277 (8.379)	1.725 (8.225)
γ_3 : Received Aid $\times$ Donor Info	6.593*** (1.860)	5.860*** (1.821)	8.450*** (2.681)	7.761*** (2.372)	-2.488 (6.242)	2.663 (6.095)	-2.248 (9.306)	0.389 (8.001)
Constant	17.894*** (0.900)	28.306*** (1.239)	19.977*** (1.560)	32.767*** (2.697)	34.385*** (2.657)	59.020*** (3.364)	41.162*** (4.937)	74.084*** (6.288)
Observations	9,308	9,308	4,594	4,594	8,546	8,541	4,139	4,127
R^2	0.593	0.773	0.591	0.820	0.624	0.821	0.545	0.858
Rounds 1+2 Data	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Individual Fixed Effects	×	✓	×	✓	×	✓	×	✓
$\gamma_2 + \gamma_3$	4.674***	3.708***	5.129***	5.63***	-1.672	-2.025	-1.971	2.113

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. Controlling for strata fixed effects (BISP receipt), survey round fixed effects, and game round fixed effects. For government fund game, controlling for giving to sports fund. For reported income game, controlling for income reported to NGO and whether participant has been audited in previous round.

ONLINE APPENDIX

Table A4: Balance at Baseline

		Means				p-values			
	# Obs. (1)	All Sample (2)	Control Group (3)	Aid Only Group (4)	Aid+Info Group (5)	Control vs. Aid Only (6)	Control vs. Aid+Info (7)	Aid Only vs. Aid+Info (8)	Omnibus Test (9)
Panel A. Het. Vars									
Married	2105	0.86	0.87	0.87	0.84	0.908	0.117	0.278	0.265
Above median age	2105	0.52	0.54	0.56	0.5	0.443	0.149	0.053	0.099
No education	2105	0.84	0.82	0.85	0.84	0.055	0.372	0.298	0.188
Household's head	2100	0.51	0.55	0.52	0.49	0.259	0.009	0.272	0.033
Above med. HH size	2105	0.61	0.63	0.62	0.6	0.669	0.212	0.542	0.456
Fin. decision-maker	2105	0.2	0.2	0.2	0.21	0.842	0.485	0.721	0.794
Panel B. Outcomes									
Days skipping meals	2105	0.59	0.59	0.58	0.6	0.931	0.825	0.661	0.927
Children skipped meals	2105	0.15	0.15	0.15	0.16	0.633	0.599	0.438	0.668
Days sleep hungry	2105	0.46	0.47	0.42	0.46	0.235	0.901	0.218	0.357
Days no eating	2105	0.25	0.25	0.25	0.25	0.983	0.72	0.735	0.914
Life satisfaction (0–10)	2105	4.47	4.52	4.53	4.41	0.995	0.293	0.419	0.501
Satisfied fin. sit.	2101	0.36	0.38	0.38	0.34	0.796	0.164	0.142	0.213
Happy	2101	0.18	0.19	0.18	0.16	0.876	0.162	0.387	0.327
Improved econ. sit.	2100	0.14	0.14	0.14	0.14	0.992	0.792	0.983	0.964
Omnibus test				0.634	0.072				

Notes: *p*-values are from regressions restricting the sample to only the groups being compared (columns 6–8) or all groups (column 9), controlling for stratification fixed effects and clustering the errors at the individual level. Column 9 shows an omnibus test in a regression of the variable considered on the two treatment indicators, testing the equality of the coefficients of the two treatment groups. The last row shows *p*-values of an omnibus test of the control group vs. the aid only group (column 4) or vs. the aid with donor information group (column 5), in which the treatment dummy is regressed on all variables considered, and then a joint test of significance of all the coefficients is estimated (controlling for stratification fixed effects).